us, we don't mind it. The BJP and Shiv Sena were in an alliance, thanks to which they have all these MPs. The Shiv Sena broke the alliance. Then its own people broke the party and they are now with us. What did we do in all this? The NDA is standing where it always has been.

Q. Coming to the Uniform Civil Code or UCC. You could have introduced it anytime in these past nine years. Why have you chosen to bring it in the final year of your government's second term?

Bringing UCC has been our commitment since the beginning. There is too much speculation. We should first wait and look at the Uttarakhand draft. It is being prepared, suggestions have been sought from the Law Commission, the process is going on. We don't look at it from the viewpoint of elections, but that of the nation.

Q. But the perception among the Opposition is that UCC is being used as a divisive issue.

The Opposition is afraid of its own shadow. What can we do about it? They see some kind of BJP ploy in everything... *desh dikhta nahin hai, pariwar dikhta hai* (they don't care about the nation, but only the 'family'). They are always trying to sweep corruption charges under the carpet. That's why when these people talk about issues and ideologies, I doubt their intentions.

Q. Coming to Karnataka where the BJP lost the elections despite its major plank being welfare; the Congress seems to have won by promising guarantees for the poor. Are the *labharthis* no longer responding to the BJP?

There's a difference between freebies and empowerment. They give freebies, we offer empowerment. And sooner or later people have to understand that. We did a lot of good work in Karnataka. But we could not communicate to the people in the right perspective. The lesson is that we have to be more communicative.



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Q. The Congress says it is also because unemployment was high and there is joblessness across the country?

First and foremost, our growth rate stands at 8.7 per cent. Those who know economics understand that this is the best place, the best situation, as a good growth rate creates jobs. Rs 10 lakh crore is being spent on infrastructure this year, which can further create employment. The PM is filling up vacancies regularly in the government sector. The Congress and the Opposition are just trying to play with people's sentiments.

Q. Rahul Gandhi accuses the BJP of fomenting hatred across the country and says there is a need to open the *mohabbat ki dukaan*. Your take?

It is the Opposition that is running a *nafrat ki dukaan*. Didn't Rahul Gandhi support the slogan, "Afzal *hum sharminda hain, tere kaatil zinda hain* (Afzal, we are sorry, your killers are still alive)"? Had it been me, you would have made me apologise 20 times. Why has nobody asked Rahul Gandhi to apologise? You say "*Modi sab chor hain* (all Modis are thieves)", but don't apologise. Such is the level of your arrogance that you insult a whole community, and then you play the victim card. What will you call this, if not hatred? You say you want to open a *mohabbat ki dukaan*, but we don't understand what love you're talking about, and towards whom? These are all methods to gain traction. ■